—they were largely cenotaphs, devoid of human bodies, suggesting different cultural beliefs (more on this below). Pottery and seals varied regionally in style and iconography.

Dholavira: The Great Metropolis of the South

The most striking feature of Dholavira today is its water management system. One gets the sense that, because of necessity, every drop of water in this arid land was saved. The city is spread over 200 acres, and about 10 per cent of it is taken up by sixteen rock-cut and/or stone-block-lined reservoirs of various sizes. They harvested water from catchment areas in the city as well as from two monsoon-season rivulets, Mandsar and Manhar, which they had dammed. Linked by intricate channels and dams, the reservoirs encircle the city's residential core. The largest of the five reservoirs excavated thus far could store nine times as much water as an Olympic-sized swimming pool and over a hundred times more water than the Great Bath of Mohenjo-Daro. Dholavira's planned residential centre, surrounded by waterbodies, must have made a visually appealing sight, and perhaps a source of pride for its residents.

Archaeologists speak of seven cultural stages in Dholavira's evolution. The settlement began around 3000 BCE with a walled fortress on a hill, and was clearly built by people who were already technologically advanced and valued urban planning. In stage two, the settlement grew northward. Stage three saw a spurt in creativity: new buildings and reservoirs came up, along with big gains in pottery art. Then came a big earthquake that damaged the fortress. Dholavira's mature phase spans stages four and five, from 2500–2000 BCE, when most of its monumental structures—gateways, fortifications, reservoirs—were built, along with a profusion of pottery, inscribed seals, weights, beads, and items of gold, silver, copper, ivory, shell, faience, soapstone, clay and stone. The fifth stage saw rising levels of impoverishment and urban decay, ending with a temporary desertion of the city, perhaps after a breakdown of its water harvesting system.[11] Then came a brief revival in stage six, at least on the citadel—a new group of Harappans arrived, who left a different cultural stamp on the artefacts from this stage. In the last stage came a group that built an entirely new style of